backwardness of the OBCs. It finally pegged the OBC population at 37 per cent, whittling it down from the 39 per cent it estimated in its interim report, and the SC accepted its report in July 2022. "When it comes to affirmative action, an empirical dataset is a must. We need scientific data on backwardness indicators like land holding, access to water, housing, education and jobs," says a member of the MSCBC.

As things stand, all sides seem to converge on the idea of a caste census, even if some in the ruling class exhibit varying degrees of enthusiasm. Prakash Shendge, former legislator and Dhangar community leader, says only a caste census can ensure clearly earmarked budgetary provisions for OBCs, like there exists for the SC/STs. "If the Centre is unwilling to launch a caste census, the state government must take the initiative," he says. At the other end of the spectrum, former Rajya Sabha MP and scion of the Kolhapur royal family, Sambhajiraje Chhatrapati, also backs the idea. He heads a political outfit, Swarajya, and had been one of the faces of the Maratha quota agitation in the past.

But there are sceptics too. Writer and activist Sanjay Sonwani notes that during caste censuses in British India, many castes claimed to belong to a more elite social group for upward mobility. For instance, the Kolis in Ahmednagar district claimed to be Kunbis. Similarly, the Dhangars in Baramati and Malegaon in Pune claimed to be Sagar Rajputs. Their caste panchayats had even passed resolutions on this.

"They had sought the status of a more privileged caste for social upliftment," explains Sonwani. "Now, a reverse process is under way where the rush is to belong to a caste lower down in the social order for quota benefits... There will be no way for the enumerators to verify the claims made by respondents about the location of their castes in the hierarchy," he says. ■

NITISH KUMAR

A WRONG BOX GETS TICKED



ANI

READY FOR THE FIGHT
Bihar chief minister Nitish Kumar speaking to mediapersons in Patna, Sept. 2

By Amitabh Srivastava

In a 48-minute-long speech that he intended as momentous, Bihar chief minister Nitish Kumar took a 27-second wrong turn that had the Opposition crying "crass" and "vulgar" and asking for his resignation, the National Commission for Women weighing in too, and Deputy CM Tejashwi Yadav offering a qualified justification. Nitish himself was forced into profuse apologies inside and outside the House the next day.

The November 7 speech was meant to convey the government's intention to expand reservations for EBCs, OBCs and SCs/STs in government jobs and educational institutions as per the findings of the recent Bihar caste survey. However, in trying to explain how education can help women intervene positively in family planning, the Bihar CM got carried away in his levity. Not even minister Ashok Choudhary's explanation that birth control was crucial in a state with the maximum population density could entirely restore the CM's well-manicured sheen.

The gaffe could not have been more ill-timed for the Opposition INDIA bloc's *sutradhar*. Of late, he had been busy trying to put new lustre on his